

CHAPTER 2

CHOOSING A MATE

We all go to school to learn the basics—reading, writing and arithmetic. But no one ever teaches us how to choose a future mate. Seems like a significant gap in the education system, if you ask me. Your mate isn't someone with whom you're going to spend an afternoon or a few sunny weeks of vacation. We're talking about *the rest of your life*. And here's the important part: your mate is going to be the biggest investment you ever make, and if you choose wrong, you're going to pay for it.

I had seen my mother's marriage to my father collapse over money trouble, and I had no desire for a repeat performance. I had also watched Georgette forge a successful partnership with George. By the time I was a teenager, I had committed the Three-Year Rule to memory and knew how to date frugally—more by necessity than by choice, I can now admit. But it wasn't until I was in my late 20s that I met the woman who would become my wife.

In the early days of SoftKey, a software company I launched that became a very lucrative business, I was still working from home—from my basement, to be exact. You might find it hard to believe, but I didn't always sit for hours at a time on the set of *Dragons' Den* or *Shark Tank*. To get my blood pumping, I'd hit the gym at the Toronto Squash Club. Back then, I was in pretty good shape—and